

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Kawasaki Heavy Industries

Aerospace Systems Company (Japan)

Engineering Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

KHI's aerospace division is one of the most distinctive organisations in this entire series — a comprehensive heavy-industry manufacturer whose aerospace programmes are inseparable from Japan's national defence sovereignty, and which is navigating an extraordinary compliance and integrity crisis at the same time as GCAP and a defence budget doubling reshape its strategic horizon. This guide consolidates the preparation tasks, signal areas, and strategic context needed to compete effectively across all relevant engineering roles.

PART I · WHAT KHI ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Seniority Level

- **Shinsotsu (New Graduate)** — KHI's new graduate selection runs a well-documented multi-stage process: ES (entry sheet) and web test → group discussion (*guruupu disukasshon* (GD)) → employee informal chat (*sha'in mendan* (which feeds into evaluation despite appearing informal)) → final interview. The final interview for technical roles is 45 minutes and covers HR discussion, a research presentation with slides and follow-up questions, a technical oral examination (*koutou shishimon* (oral technical exam)) on engineering fundamentals, and motivation questions. The oral exam specifically tests the *yonrikigaku* (four mechanics): fluid mechanics (*ryuutai rikigaku* ()), strength of materials (*zairyou rikigaku* ()), thermodynamics (*netsurikigaku* ()), and dynamics/vibration (*kikai rikigaku* ()). Confirmed questions include Bernoulli's theorem, stress-strain diagrams, three modes of heat transfer, and resonance — all expected to be explained clearly and accurately without notes.

The specific filter at graduate level is the combination of technical specialist depth appropriate to the engineering discipline major (*senko* (major discipline)) and genuine commitment to manufacturing engineering (*monozukuri* (the art of making things)) as a career — not just interest in aerospace as a concept. The key qualities sought are domain expertise and a challenger spirit — candidates who are persistent in the face of technical failure and who genuinely want to contribute to irreplaceable engineering work.

- **Chuto Saiyou (Mid-Career Experienced Hire)** — Mid-career hiring at KHI involves document screening followed by two interview rounds, described as conversational in atmosphere. The interview often begins with the interviewer introducing the team's work, challenges, and direction, then the questioning focuses on professional experience, expertise, career expectations, and certifications. Candidates from the same industry are reportedly given higher priority. A defence-specific question confirmed in recent interviews: "Do you have any resistance to meeting with Ministry of Defense (*Boueisho* ()) personnel?" This is not a trick question — it is a practical screen for whether an engineer is genuinely comfortable in the MOD programme interface environment that defines KHI's JMOD-facing work.

The context that makes 2025–2026 mid-career hiring at KHI particularly specific: in August 2024, KHI admitted deliberately manipulating test data on 674 ship engines built since 2000 — 20 years of systematic falsification — followed by investigations into possible tampering of submarine engine fuel efficiency data and bribery allegations involving Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force personnel over submarine re-

pair contracts. Engineers joining KHI in 2025–2026 are entering an organisation in an active compliance remediation period. The ability to demonstrate a personal professional ethics orientation — and the composure to acknowledge the institutional context honestly — is a live interview filter.

- **Jokyu-shoku (Senior / Principal Engineer)** — At senior level, KHI is looking for engineers who can carry technical authority on JMOD programmes (P-1, C-2, helicopter programmes) or commercial aerostructures (Boeing 787 fuselage sections, Embraer structures) and who can — increasingly — operate in the multinational programme environment that GCAP is creating. Japan’s defence programme is undergoing a historic transformation: GCAP requires Japanese engineers to learn entirely new skills of operating in a complex international multi-partner programme, with company-to-company technology exchanges rather than the traditional government-to-government model, enhanced information security, and digital design tools for GCAP’s digital thread integration. Senior KHI engineers who have operated in international programmes are specifically valued for this reason.

Japan’s Special Secrets protection law (*Tokutei Himitsu Hogohou* (enacted 2014)) and its accompanying clearance system create structural barriers at senior level: clearances are not portable between employers, so a cleared engineer leaving MHI or IHI for KHI faces a re-clearance process that can take months — combined with Japan’s lifetime employment norms, this means that the vast majority of senior candidates in defence aerospace are passive and not actively searching.

Hands-On Signal Areas

Domain	Core Competencies Expected
Yonrikigaku (Four Mechanics)	The oral technical examination specifically tests fluid mechanics, strength of materials, thermodynamics, and dynamics/vibration at textbook-plus depth. Mid and senior engineers are expected to have these as a living professional tool, not just academic memory.
JMOD Programme Familiarity	KHI is prime contractor for the P-1 Maritime Patrol Aircraft and C-2 transport. Understanding how ATLA (<i>Bouei Soubichou</i> (Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency)) manages programme requirements, specification review, and acceptance is the operational context for all KHI defence engineering work.
Boeing / Embraer Aerostructures	KHI manufactures the centre wing box and forward fuselage sections for the Boeing 787, and structures for the Embraer 170/175/190/195 family. Engineers with composite aerostructures, large-section assembly, or quality management for Boeing or Embraer programmes have directly transferable experience.
Japanese Language (Professional Level)	KHI's engineering work at the Gifu Works (aircraft) and Kobe Works is conducted in Japanese. Design reviews, supplier meetings, ATLA programme interfaces, and team engineering discussions all happen in Japanese. Non-negotiable for Gifu and Kobe-based roles.
GCAP-Relevant Technologies	GCAP requires composite stealth structures, titanium alloy machining, additive manufacturing for defence applications, and MBSE for digital thread integration — disciplines distinct from the commercial aluminium airframe construction or licensed production expertise that has historically dominated Japanese aerospace.
Quality Management System Experience	Given KHI's 2024 data falsification scandal, demonstrated personal commitment to rigorous quality management — AS9100, JISQ9100, or equivalent — and the ability to name specific process improvements you have led, is a distinguishing signal.
Research Presentation Capability	The graduate final interview requires a slide-based research presentation with technical follow-up. For mid-career R&D roles, an equivalent <i>purezen</i> (presentation) format is used.

How KHI's Interview Format Differs from Standard Tech and Other Companies

- **The oral technical examination (*koutou shishimon* (live oral exam)) is a test of engineering fundamentals, not just a career conversation.** The oral exam was not announced in advance but was conducted at the final interview — questions covered Bernoulli's theorem, stress-strain diagrams, the three modes of heat transfer, and resonance. It tests whether engineering fundamentals are genuinely internalised.
- **The group discussion (GD) is about observable communication behaviour, not subject matter expertise.** The GD uses a social or business topic — for example, “decide the top three activities parents should have children learn” — specifically to evaluate discussion ability only, not technical knowledge. Assessors observe: whether you invite quieter participants to contribute, whether you build on others' ideas, whether you manage time toward a conclusion, and whether you can hold a position while remaining collegial.
- **The informal employee chat (*sha'in mendan* (employee meeting)) feeds into evaluation despite ap-**

peering social. Its contents are reported to HR and do influence evaluation. Candidates who treat it as genuine downtime are evaluated as less perceptive.

- **The mid-career interview is conversational and manager-led, starting with an introduction of the team.** Questions then focus on professional history, capabilities, career expectations, and specialist certifications. This requires candidates to listen carefully to the team context being described before their answers.
- **The ES (Entry Sheet) is the first written filter.** KHI's ES asks about research content, motivation for applying, strength as an engineer, and what kind of engineer you want to become. The university recommendation (*gakkou suisen* ()) route is available for technical disciplines — a formal recommendation letter materially improves screening odds.
- **The compliance context must be navigated professionally.** Questions about “your approach to quality management” or “a time when you raised a concern about data or process” are live at KHI in ways they are not at most other companies in this series.
- **Japanese language is the working language for all domestic roles.** All interviews at Gifu and Kobe sites are conducted in Japanese. The technical presentation is in Japanese. The oral examination is in Japanese. Engineering candidates without professional Japanese proficiency (JLPT N2 or above; N1 for programme leadership) are not competitive for domestic site roles.

Honest caveat on format variation: KHI's aerospace division operates primarily from the Gifu Works (aircraft manufacturing and assembly) and the Kobe/Akashi sites (aerostructure elements, engines). Commercial aerostructures, JMOD aircraft, and helicopter programmes each have different team cultures and interview emphases. Mid-career format varies somewhat by division and hiring urgency. This guide targets the Aerospace Systems Company in Japan.

PART II · 20 SPECIFIC PREPARATION TASKS

Shinsotsu / New Graduate

1. Master the *Yonrikigaku* (Four Mechanics) to Oral-Explanation Depth — Not Just Textbook Memory 5–6 h

Skill: The primary technical screen at KHI's final interview — administered without advance notice as a live oral exam

Objective: The oral technical exam covers the four mechanics and requires clear spoken explanations of fundamentals including Bernoulli's theorem, stress-strain diagrams, three modes of heat transfer, and resonance. These are not edge-case questions — they are foundational engineering. The exam tests whether understanding is genuine and articulable, not just stored in memory.

Done Signal: You can explain each of the following out loud, in Japanese, in under 2 minutes each, without notes: Bernoulli's theorem and its assumptions; the stress-strain curve including elastic limit, yield point, and fracture; the three modes of heat transfer and the dominant conditions for each; and resonance including natural frequency and what happens when excitation frequency approaches it. A Japanese engineer has heard your explanations and confirmed they are accurate and clear.

2. Prepare the Research Presentation (*Kenkyuu Happyou*) in Japanese — for a Mixed HR/Technical Panel 4–5 h

Skill: The formal technical communication element of KHI’s final interview for technical graduates

Objective: The final interview includes a slide-based research presentation with follow-up questions from the technical engineers on the panel. The panel consists of one HR person and two technical engineers; the technical engineers specifically ask follow-up questions on the research. The presentation must be accessible to a non-specialist while remaining technically credible to the engineers.

Done Signal: You have a 10-minute research presentation in Japanese (approximately 5–8 slides) that: opens with the problem your research addresses in terms a non-specialist can understand, describes your specific methodology and why it was chosen, presents key results with numbers, addresses one failure or setback and how you responded, and closes with a clear conclusion and next steps. You have delivered it twice with a Japanese engineer asking follow-up questions, and answered all follow-ups without going vague.

3. Write a Compelling ES (Entry Sheet) in Japanese — Tailored to KHI’s Aerospace Systems Company 4–5 h

Skill: Written application quality as the first document screening filter

Objective: The ES is the first filter. Standard KHI ES questions include: research overview, motivation for applying, your strength as an engineer (*gijutsushatoshite no tsuyomi* ()), and what kind of engineer you want to become (*donna kijutsusha ni naritai ka* ()). Generic answers that could apply to MHI, IHI, or any Japanese manufacturer are recognised immediately. The expected ES answer connects your specific academic background to a specific KHI programme or technical domain.

Done Signal: You have written answers to all standard ES questions, each specifically naming a KHI programme (P-1, C-2, BK117, Boeing 787 aerostructures, jet engine development) and connecting your engineering background to the technical challenge it presents. A native Japanese speaker has reviewed each answer for language quality, professional register, and cultural appropriateness for a Japanese corporate audience.

4. Prepare for the Group Discussion (*Guruupu Disukasshon*) — Practise Collaborative Discussion on Social/Business Topics in Japanese 2–3 h

Skill: Observable group discussion behaviour for the GD selection stage

Objective: The group discussion uses everyday social topics like “decide the top three activities parents should have children learn” — specifically designed to evaluate discussion ability, not technical knowledge. Assessors observe communication, teamwork, and leadership behaviours. The strongest GD performers open the discussion with a clear structural framing, invite contributions from quieter participants, build on others’ ideas rather than just advancing their own, and help the group reach a consensus within the time limit.

Done Signal: You have participated in at least two mock GDs in Japanese — one with 4–6 people on a social topic — and received feedback from an observer on specific behaviours: whether you invited others to speak, whether you managed toward a conclusion, whether you built on others’ points, and whether your Japanese was clear enough for the group to follow. You have corrected at least one specific observed behaviour.

5. Know KHI’s Aerospace Programme Portfolio at Technical Depth — Especially P-1, C-2, and BK117 4 h

Skill: Programme knowledge that enables a peer conversation with the technical panel

4 h

Objective: The technical engineers on the final interview panel are working on KHI's actual programmes. A graduate who knows only that KHI "makes aircraft" has not engaged with the specific engineering work they are applying to join. KHI is prime contractor for the P-1 maritime patrol aircraft and C-2 transport for the JMOD — alongside the BK117 helicopter jointly developed with Airbus Helicopters.

Done Signal: For the P-1, C-2, and BK117, you can state in Japanese: the platform's primary mission and operator, the key technical features, KHI's specific development role, one specific engineering challenge the programme faced or faces, and why KHI's engineering capability was essential. You can answer one follow-up question on each.

6. Prepare a Specific Answer to "Naze Kawasaki Jukogyoka?" (Why KHI?) — Naming a Specific Programme and Engineering Contribution

2 h

Skill: Company-specific motivation that addresses KHI's unique position among Japanese heavy manufacturers

Objective: This question is asked in every KHI interview. The expected answer names a specific KHI programme, explains one technically specific aspect of it that is uniquely available at KHI (not at MHI, IHI, or Subaru), and connects the candidate's academic background to contributing to it. Generic answers about wanting to work in aerospace or defence, or describing KHI as a "stable" company, do not differentiate.

Done Signal: You have a 90-second answer in Japanese that names your target KHI programme, explains one specific engineering challenge it presents, connects your research or academic background to addressing that challenge, and contains one sentence about why KHI's role in this programme — not a competitor's — is the specific opportunity you want. The answer cannot be given unchanged to MHI or IHI.

Chuto Saiyou / Mid-Career Experienced Hire

All graduate tasks still apply. The research presentation must cover professional project work. Japanese must be at business working level (N2 minimum, N1 preferred for Gifu-based roles). *Yon-rikigaku* fluency is expected as a professional baseline, not a subject to prepare for.

7. Prepare a Specific Answer to "Bouei-sho no kata to au koto ni teikouwa nai ka?" (Do You Have Any Resistance to Meeting with Ministry of Defense Personnel?)

1 h

Skill: JMOD programme interface readiness — a direct KHI mid-career screen question

Objective: This question was confirmed in a recent KHI Aerospace Systems Company mid-career interview. It is asking whether you are prepared to regularly interface with JMOD/ATLA programme officers, attend formal government review meetings, represent KHI's technical position in government settings, and accept the documentation discipline and confidentiality expectations that government programme interface involves. Candidates who are visibly hesitant suggest poor cultural fit for KHI's most significant business relationships.

Done Signal: You have a prepared, confident answer in Japanese that affirms your comfort with JMOD/ATLA interface, ideally with a brief example of a formal government or regulatory customer interaction you have had — naming the agency or customer type, the nature of the meeting or review, and your role.

8. Build Deep Knowledge of ATLA (*Bouei Soubichou*) and Japan's Defence Programme Lifecycle 4–5 h

Skill: Japanese defence acquisition framework operational literacy

Objective: Japan's Acquisition, Technology and Logistics Agency (ATLA, established 2015) manages all JMOD equipment procurement from requirements through acceptance. It is the Japanese counterpart of DAPA in Korea, DES in the UK, or the DoD Acquisition Executive in the US. Understanding the Japanese procurement lifecycle — from *gainen kenkyuu* (concept study) through *shisaku* (prototype) to *ryousan* (mass production) to *un'you* (operations and support) — is the operational framework within which all KHI JMOD engineering work occurs.

Done Signal: You can explain what ATLA is and when it was established, describe the key phases of a Japanese JMOD programme lifecycle, explain how *Bouei-sho Kikaku* (JMOD specifications/standards, equivalent to DEF STANs or MIL-STDs) govern KHI's engineering deliverables, and describe how *kenshu* (final acceptance) by ATLA differs from commercial customer acceptance in terms of process and documentation.

9. Prepare a Story About Your Experience in a Formal Quality Management System — and How You Personally Contributed to Data or Process Integrity 2 h

Skill: Quality management credibility in the specific context of KHI's 2024 data scandal

Objective: KHI admitted in August 2024 to deliberately manipulating test data on 674 ship engines for more than 20 years, followed by further investigations into submarine engine data integrity. An interviewer who has been inside KHI through this crisis is specifically alert to whether a candidate demonstrates a genuine, functional commitment to quality and data integrity — not just nominal agreement with quality principles. A story that names a specific quality system, a specific data integrity challenge, and your personal action to address it is a uniquely powerful differentiator at this moment in KHI's institutional history.

Done Signal: You have a story about working within a formal quality management system (AS9100, JISQ9100, ISO 9001, or programme-specific equivalent) where a data integrity question, a non-conformance, or a process deviation arose. You can name the system, describe the specific issue, explain what you personally did (not what the team did), and describe the formal outcome. The story demonstrates that you treat quality process compliance as a professional responsibility, not as bureaucratic overhead.

10. Study the Boeing 787 and Embraer Commercial Aerostructures Programmes — KHI's Role and Current Status 3 h

Skill: Commercial aviation aerostructures context for KHI's international programme work

Objective: KHI manufactures the centre wing box and forward fuselage sections for the Boeing 787, and structural components for the Embraer 170/175/190/195 family. These commercial programmes run in parallel with JMOD military aircraft production. Engineers from the commercial aerostructures world who understand Boeing's production system, quality requirements (D6 standards, Boeing supplier portal), or Embraer's equivalent have directly transferable experience. Understanding the current production status — particularly the Boeing 787 supply chain context after Boeing's quality crisis — demonstrates market awareness.

Done Signal: You can describe KHI's specific role in the 787 programme (which sections, what manufacturing process), explain what the centre wing box is structurally and why it is a critical manufacturing challenge, describe the Boeing supplier quality management interface, and discuss how Boeing's ongoing quality challenges affect KHI's programme relationship. You can do this in Japanese.

11. Prepare a Story Demonstrating Your Experience with a Government Defence Programme — Specifically Programme Milestone Reviews and Requirements Management 1–2 h

Skill: Government programme interface experience for KHI's JMOD-facing work

Objective: KHI's P-1, C-2, and helicopter programmes all involve formal JMOD/ATLA milestone reviews, detailed requirements management against Japanese defence standards, and a long-running programme relationship with a government customer that places unique demands on documentation, traceability, and technical communication. Engineers who have only worked in commercial programmes without government programme experience are missing the specific professional dimension that defines KHI's most important business relationships.

Done Signal: You have a story about working on a programme with a government or defence customer — you can name the government agency or customer type, describe the milestone review you contributed to, explain what documentation you prepared and how it was reviewed, and describe how a government comment or question was formally resolved.

12. Understand GCAP and Kawasaki's Potential Role — Including the Tri-National Workshare Complexity 4 h

Skill: The programme that will define Japanese aerospace's next 50 years — and KHI's place in it

Objective: GCAP requires Japan's engineers to develop entirely new skills of operating in a complex international multi-partner project, with company-to-company technology exchanges, enhanced information security, and digital design tools for digital thread integration — capabilities different from Japan's traditional government-to-government technology transfer model. While MHI leads Japan's GCAP workshare, KHI contributes as a supply chain participant — and the C-2 transport has been discussed as a potential GCAP flight test aircraft. The GCAP programme is transforming the entire Japanese aerospace industrial base and KHI is part of that ecosystem.

Done Signal: You can explain what GCAP is, who the three industrial partners are (BAE Systems, Leonardo, JAIEC/MHI for Japan), what Japan's workshare includes, why Japan changed its arms export policy in March 2024 to enable GCAP exports, what specific engineering challenges Japan faces in moving from licensed production to sixth-generation indigenous design (stealth structures, digital design tools, multinational IP management), and what role KHI specifically might play. You can discuss this in Japanese.

13. Prepare a Story About Navigating a Difficult Technical Problem in a Cross-Functional Team — Where Your Domain Expertise Bridged a Gap Between Specialisms 1–2 h

Skill: Cross-functional technical collaboration for KHI's complex systems programmes

Objective: KHI's P-1 and C-2 programmes required integrating aerodynamics, structures, avionics, propulsion, systems engineering, and manufacturing — across internal KHI teams and external suppliers. Engineers who can bridge between engineering disciplines are more useful to integrated programme teams than those who can only operate within their own specialisation.

Done Signal: You have a story where a problem required understanding from at least two distinct engineering disciplines, you facilitated the connection between the two technical teams, and the outcome depended on your bridge-building rather than on either specialist team acting alone. The story names the two disciplines, the specific technical tension, what you did to facilitate, and what the programme outcome was.

Jokyu-shoku / Senior and Principal Engineer

All mid-career tasks still apply. ATLA process knowledge (task 8) must be operational — you should have led or substantially contributed to a formal government milestone review. The quality story (task 9) must involve a programme-level quality improvement, not a single incident response.

14. Prepare to Walk Through a Complete Aircraft Programme Phase You Led — from Requirements Through JMOD/ATLA Acceptance 4–6 h

Skill: End-to-end development ownership in Japan's government defence procurement context

Objective: Senior KHI engineers own technical threads that span from requirements definition through ATLA formal acceptance — a process that takes years, involves formal government design reviews, and culminates in *kenshu* (acceptance testing) conducted by ATLA programme officers. The interview at this level probes whether you have actually owned a thread like this — or whether you contributed to one owned by someone else. The specific KHI dimension is that much of this work is done for the first time in Japan (P-1, C-2 were both Japan-firsts in their class), so the institutional precedent is limited and individual engineering judgement is correspondingly more significant.

Done Signal: For one programme phase or major subsystem you personally owned the technical thread for, you can answer questions without notes at every phase — the requirements source, the design authority decisions and their trade-offs, the verification/validation strategy, the key ATLA review comment that was hardest to resolve, and the formal acceptance document. You can describe how the absence of domestic precedent shaped your approach.

15. Prepare a Technically Grounded Position on the Specific Engineering Challenges KHI Faces in the GCAP Context — Composite Stealth Structures, Digital Thread, and Multinational IP 4 h

Skill: Senior forward-looking technical engagement with Japan's most consequential aerospace programme

Objective: GCAP requires composite stealth structures, titanium alloy machining, additive manufacturing, and MBSE for digital thread integration — distinct from the aluminium airframe construction and licensed production expertise that has historically dominated Japanese aerospace. The skills gap is systemic across the cluster. Senior KHI engineers are expected to have thought seriously about what this transition requires — technically, organisationally, and in terms of international programme management.

Done Signal: You have a prepared 3-minute technical discussion of one specific engineering challenge GCAP creates for KHI — named specifically (stealth composite fabrication process control, MBSE tool selection and integration for digital thread, ITAR and Japanese security regulations at the interface of GCAP's tri-national data sharing, or additive manufacturing certification for structural components). Your position is technically grounded, acknowledges Japan's current capability honestly, and describes a specific development path.

16. Prepare to Discuss the 2024 KHI Data Integrity Scandal — Professionally, Factually, and with a Considered View on What Cultural Change It Requires 2 h

Skill: Corporate compliance context engagement that demonstrates senior professional maturity

Objective: The test data manipulation scandal — 674 ship engines, 20 years, and subsequent submarine investigations — is a defining institutional moment for KHI that every senior engineer hired in 2025–2026 will enter. Senior candidates who are unaware of it, or who dismiss it as unrelated to their engineering domain, are demonstrating a lack of situational awareness that is disqualifying at senior level. The expected senior response is a factual, honest, professional engagement that includes: what

happened, what it indicates about the quality culture that permitted it to continue, and what a senior engineer's responsibility is in building a culture where data integrity is non-negotiable. 2 h

Done Signal: You can describe the 2024 KHI scandal accurately and concisely in Japanese (what was falsified, for how long, in which division, and what the regulatory and reputational consequences were), articulate one specific cultural or process factor that can sustain data falsification over decades without detection, and describe the personal professional standard you would bring to KHI's quality culture remediation. The answer is factual, calm, not performatively shocked, and demonstrates that you have thought about it seriously.

17. Prepare Specific Examples of Technical Knowledge Transfer to Junior Engineers — in a Manufacturing or Programme Engineering Context 1–2 h

Skill: Technical succession in an organisation with a traditional skills transmission culture (*waza no densho*)

Objective: KHI's *monozukuri* (art of making things) culture places explicit value on skilled craftsmanship and its transmission across generations. KHI has a Traditional Skill Master System that certifies skilled production specialists to pass down their skills, and holds annual Technical Skill Contests where young employees from Japan and overseas compete. Senior engineers are expected to embody and transfer technical knowledge that cannot be found in documentation — the tacit knowledge of how to machine a complex component correctly, how to interpret a vibration signature during engine testing, or how to manage a structural test setup.

Done Signal: You have a story where you transferred a specific, non-obvious technical skill to a junior engineer — the skill is named, your teaching approach is described, and the outcome that demonstrates independent application by the junior engineer is identified. The skill should be one that is not easily conveyed in written documentation — a physical craft, a diagnostic judgement, a test interpretation heuristic.

18. Build Quantitative Estimation Fluency for Aerospace Performance Parameters in Your Domain — Applicable to the Four Mechanics 4 h

Skill: Engineering first-principles reasoning that demonstrates living knowledge, not stored memory

Objective: Senior KHI engineers are expected to sanity-check analysis results, catch errors in supplier calculations, and respond credibly to “does this number make sense?” in programme reviews — whether the question is about a structural load, a thermal margin, a fluid pressure, or a vibration frequency. At senior level, the four mechanics are expected to be fluent daily tools, not exam subjects. The oral exam questions become applied system-level problems, not definitions.

Done Signal: You have worked through five aerospace performance estimation problems in your domain in Japanese — stated out loud, assumptions named before numbers — arriving at order-of-magnitude answers with stated uncertainty. The problems span at least two of the four mechanics (e.g., structural load in a wing under 2.5g manoeuvre combined with a heat transfer estimate for an avionics bay). You can identify the most load-bearing assumption in each and how you would verify it with test data.

All Levels

19. Prepare a Specific Answer to “*Donna gijutsusha ni naritai ka?*” (What Kind of Engineer Do You Want to Become?) — Grounded in KHI’s Specific Technical Programmes 1–2 h

Skill: Career aspiration articulation that connects to KHI’s engineering identity

Objective: This question appears on KHI’s ES and in every level of interview. The expected answer at KHI specifically connects to the *monozukuri* (art of making things) engineering identity — the combination of technical depth, craftsmanship, and long-term programme commitment that KHI’s culture values. Generic answers about “becoming a globally competitive engineer” or “contributing to society through technology” are heard hundreds of times. The answer that distinguishes a motivated candidate names a specific type of technical mastery (compressor aerodynamics, composite structures, flight control systems), connects it to a specific KHI programme context, and frames it as a lifetime professional aspiration rather than a 3-year career plan.

Done Signal: You have a 90-second answer in Japanese that names the specific engineering domain you want to master, the specific KHI programme or technical challenge you want to contribute to, and what kind of engineer you see yourself as in 10–15 years — not in terms of seniority but in terms of technical capability and contribution. The answer resonates with a Japanese heavy manufacturing engineering culture rather than with a tech company or startup culture.

20. Verify Japanese Language Proficiency, Travel/Relocation Flexibility, and Special Secrets Clearance Eligibility 1–2 h

Skill: Eligibility self-knowledge for the three most common candidacy-blocking factors at KHI

Objective: Three factors frequently limit candidates who have not researched them: Japanese language (engineering roles at Gifu and Kobe require professional working Japanese, confirmed in job postings and interview descriptions), travel and relocation flexibility (confirmed interview questions include “can you accept overseas travel?” and “can you relocate?” — KHI has sites in Gifu, Kobe, and Akashi and expects geographic flexibility), and Japanese Special Secrets clearance eligibility (*Tokutei Himitsu Toriatsukaisha* () clearance for classified JMOD programmes requires Japanese nationality for most roles, with five years’ continuous Japan residency as a baseline for non-Japanese applicants in some circumstances).

Done Signal: You know your JLPT level or equivalent, can honestly characterise your Japanese technical communication capability, have confirmed travel and relocation flexibility with a clear answer, have researched what Special Secrets clearance requires for your nationality, and can answer all three eligibility questions clearly and without hesitation in a recruiter screen. If any factor is a limitation, you have identified which roles are accessible given your actual profile.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	<i>Yonrikigaku</i> (Four Mechanics) to oral explanation depth in Japanese	All	5–6 h
2	Research presentation (<i>Kenkyuu Happyou</i>) in Japanese — 10 min + Q&A	All	4–5 h
3	ES answers — programme-specific, KHI-tailored, in Japanese	All	4–5 h
4	Group discussion (GD) practice in Japanese	All	2–3 h
5	KHI programme portfolio — P-1, C-2, BK117 at technical depth	All	4 h
6	“ <i>Naze Kawasaki Jukogyoka?</i> ” — programme-specific in Japanese	All	2 h
7	MOD personnel interface answer — confident and specific	Mid+	1 h
8	ATLA (<i>Bouei Soubichou</i>) and Japanese defence programme lifecycle	Mid+	4–5 h
9	Quality/data integrity story — specific and personal	Mid+	2 h
10	Boeing 787 and Embraer aerostructures — KHI’s role	Mid+	3 h
11	Government programme milestone review story	Mid+	1–2 h
12	GCAP — Japan’s role, workshare complexity, skills gap	Mid+	4 h
13	Cross-discipline technical bridge story	Mid+	1–2 h
14	Full programme phase from requirements to ATLA acceptance	Senior	4–6 h
15	GCAP engineering challenge — KHI-specific technical position	Senior	4 h
16	2024 data scandal — factual, professional, mature engagement	Senior	2 h
17	Technical knowledge transfer — <i>waza no densho</i> in practice	Senior	1–2 h
18	Aerospace performance estimation — Four Mechanics applied	Senior	4 h
19	“ <i>Donna gijutsusha ni naritai ka?</i> ” — KHI-grounded aspiration	All	1–2 h
20	JLPT, relocation, and Special Secrets eligibility verification	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY

KHI has been building aircraft in Japan for over a century — since the Imperial Army Air Force ordered fighters in the 1930s, through post-war licensed production of American patrol aircraft and helicopters, through the C-1 (Japan’s first indigenous jet transport, 1970), through the T-4 (Blue Impulse aerobatics), and now through the P-1 maritime patrol aircraft and C-2 transport, each of which was developed from a blank sheet of Japanese engineering — built in Japan, certified in Japan, operated by Japanese forces, without a foreign prime contractor.

The engineers who succeed at KHI are those who understand that this heritage of *monozukuri* (the art of making things) — the belief that the act of making things with care and skill is itself a form of national and cultural contribution — is not nostalgia but a living operational philosophy. And who understand that this same heritage, in 2024, produced a 20-year data falsification scandal that calls that philosophy into question in the most serious way since the war.

The candidates who impress in 2025–2026 are those who hold both of these truths simultaneously — who honour the engineering legacy of Kawasaki while being honest about what failed and personally committed to what must be different.

